



CRISTIANO RONALDO

A fierce free-kick into the far bottom corner. A wide-eyed, fiery roar after the ball ruffled the net. An impromptu jig with his teammates, who had run into him. At 41, Cristiano Ronaldo had done it again. The mercurial Portuguese forward ended Al Nassr's seven-year wait for a Saudi Pro League title with a brace in a final-day 4-1 win against Damac. It was the 36th trophy in an illustrious career where he has scored a staggering

973 goals

for club and country

The ace goalscorer has also tasted success with Portugal, winning Euro 2016 and two UEFA Nations Leagues. But there is still one unrealised dream — the World Cup.

Ronaldo has scored eight goals across five campaigns but has crossed the quarterfinal stage only once (2006). He is also yet to score a knockout goal for his country. This could be his last chance to complete the set.

INTERNATIONAL STATS

Caps | Goals
226 | **143**

Assists 46

FINAL FLOURISH FOR CR7?

Cristiano Ronaldo, along with Lionel Messi, could become two of only three players to have played in six World Cups. While Messi has already won the trophy once, Ronaldo will eye a chance to finally win the title in Portugal colours, marking the end of a rivalry arc that has historically seen them compete for Ballon d'Ors and club trophies.

ERLING HAALAND

Considering how Erling Haaland has become the gold standard for strikers of the modern generation, it is surprising that he will only be making his first major international tournament appearance at the World Cup. In a season of fluctuating fortunes for Manchester City, the 25-year-old quietly walked away with the Premier League Golden Boot with

27 goals

and looks primed to lead the Nordic nation's challenge in North America.

He holds the staggering all-time record of 55 goals for his country in just 49 games, which includes the 16 he bagged in the qualifiers.

And with almost all honours a player can dream of already secured at the club level, now, Haaland will have the opportunity to etch his name among the greats when Norway makes its first Finals appearance since 1998. His menacing presence, combined with his aerial ability, is expected to trouble opposition defences, especially since he will be linking up with Europe-proven players like Martin Odegaard and Alexander Sorloth.

INTERNATIONAL STATS

Caps | Goals
49 | **55**

Assists 6

1962

In 2025, with goals in 11 consecutive internationals, Haaland levelled the record set by Abdul Ghani Minhat in 1962

